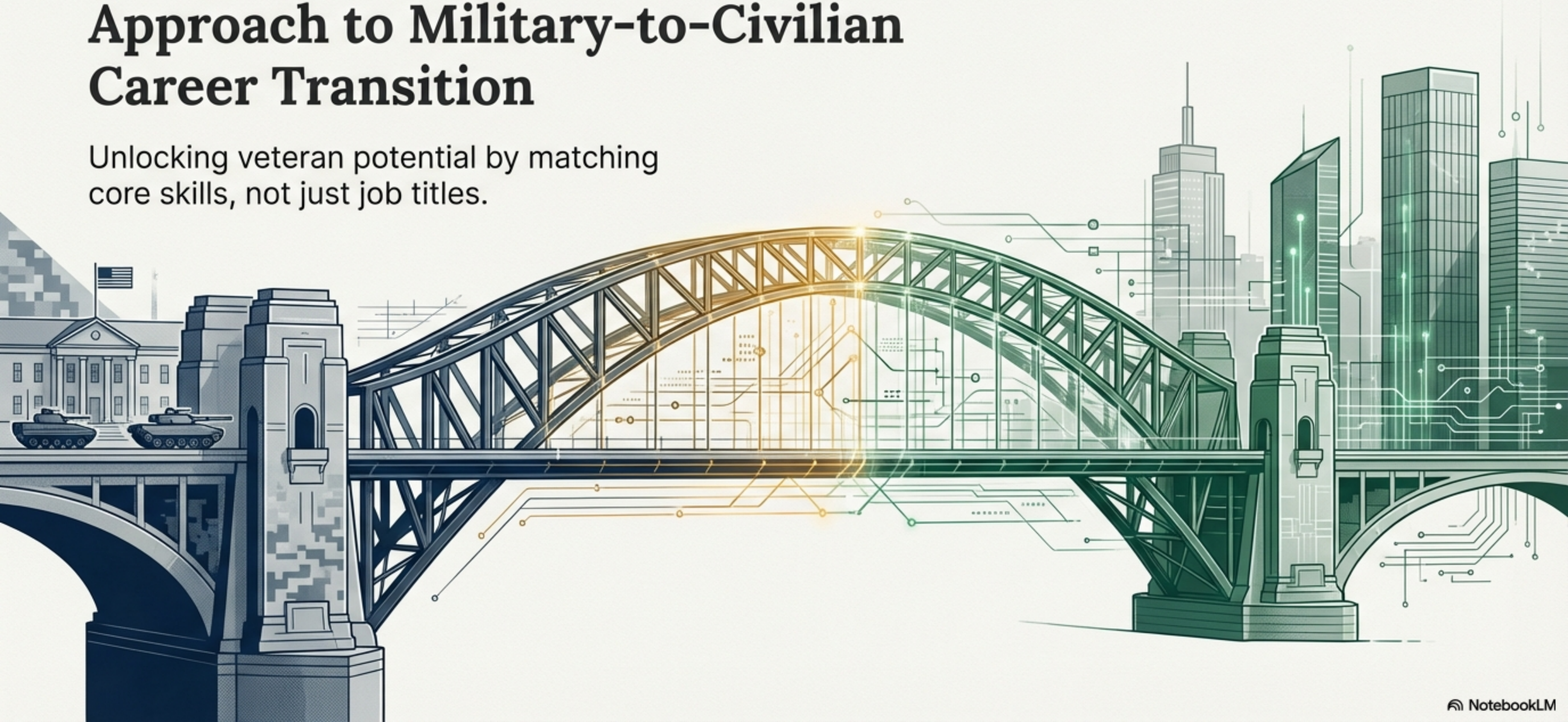


Bridging the Gap: A New Data-Driven Approach to Military-to-Civilian Career Transition

Unlocking veteran potential by matching core skills, not just job titles.



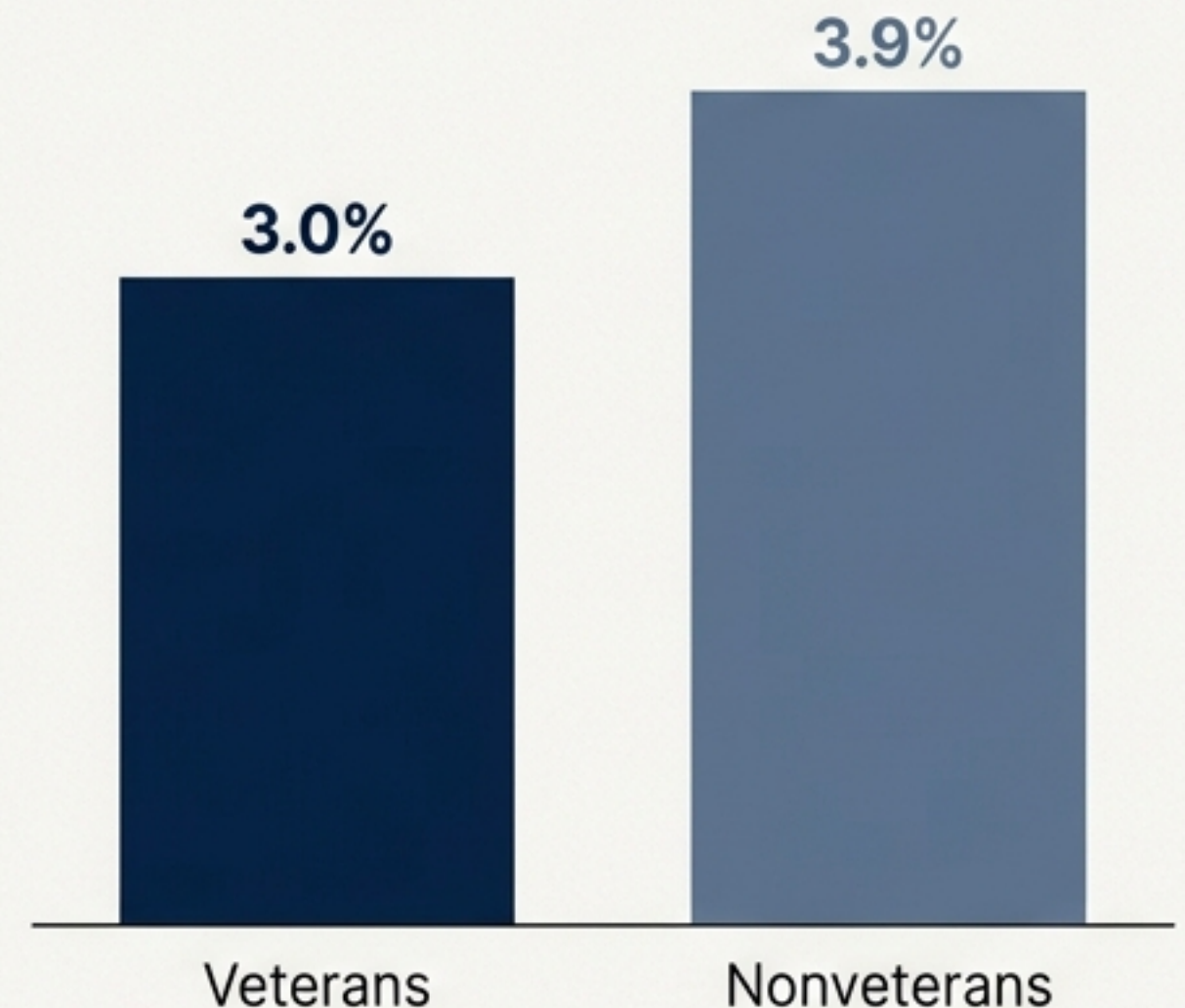
The veteran employment landscape is strong, with unemployment rates lower than their civilian counterparts.

In 2024, the United States was home to 17.6 million veterans, comprising about 7% of the adult civilian population. Data consistently shows that on average, veterans are more likely to be employed than their nonveteran peers.

Source: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Employment Situation of Veterans — 2024

3.0%

Veteran Unemployment Rate
vs. Nonveteran Rate (2024)



Post-9/11 veterans are a large, highly skilled, and actively participating segment of the U.S. workforce.



5.3 MILLION

Gulf War-era II Veterans



79.3%

Labor Force Participation



3.2%

Unemployment Rate

Insight Box

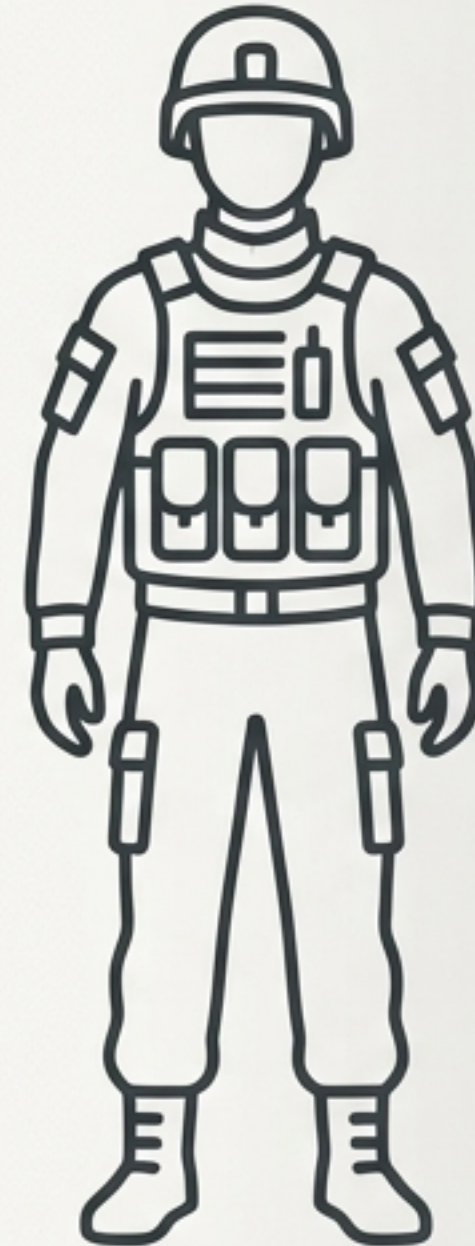
Post-9/11 veterans are more likely than their nonveteran peers to work in management and professional occupations and twice as likely to work in the public sector.

However, these positive top-line numbers mask a persistent challenge: the “translation gap” for specialized military skills.

200,000

U.S. service members transition to civilian life each year.

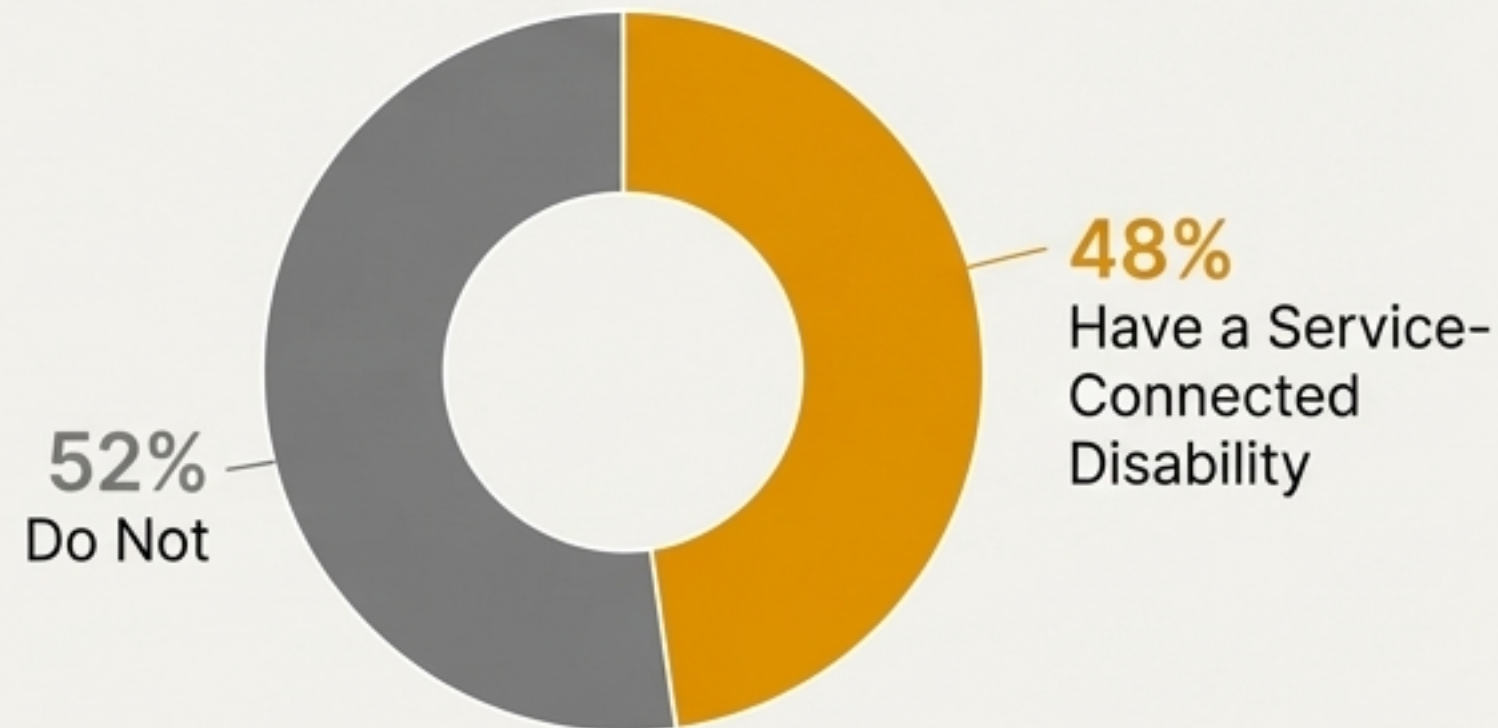
- Many military occupations, especially in combat-arms fields (e.g., infantry, ordnance), have no direct parallel in the civilian economy.
- This translation difficulty can lead to underemployment, where veterans take jobs that do not fully utilize the advanced skills and leadership they developed in service.
- Civilian employers often struggle to recognize the value of military experience without a clear civilian equivalent.



The translation challenge is most acute for the nearly half of Post-9/11 veterans with a service-connected disability.

48%

Service-Connected Disability Among
Gulf War-era II Veterans



- While overall unemployment for this group is not statistically different, labor force participation is lower for those with disabilities (77.3% vs. 84.8% for those without).
- Participation drops significantly as the disability rating increases. Veterans with a rating of 60% or higher have a participation rate of just 74.5%.
- These veterans possess valuable skills but may need more targeted career pathways that accommodate their conditions.

A new methodology bridges the gap by deconstructing jobs into their core components: Knowledge, Skills, and Abilities (KSAs).

The RAND Corporation, sponsored by the Department of Defense, developed an algorithmic approach to create an “apples-to-apples” comparison between military and civilian occupations. This method moves beyond analyzing high-level job descriptions.



This approach systematically identifies similarities that are not obvious from job titles alone.



The approach leverages the Department of Labor's O*NET framework to create a universal standard for job analysis.

1. **Data Collection:** Over 5,100 active-duty personnel across the Navy, Marine Corps, and Air Force completed the same O*NET survey used to profile civilian jobs.
2. **Comprehensive Profiling:** Each job is profiled across 234 distinct items in six modules: Knowledge, Skills, Abilities, Work Activities, Work Context, and Work Styles.
3. **Algorithmic Matching:** A 'distance metric' calculates the similarity between a military role and every civilian occupation, generating a ranked match score from 0 (worst match) to 100 (best match).

For a Marine Corps Infantry Rifleman, conventional career paths are limited and often fail to capture their advanced skills.

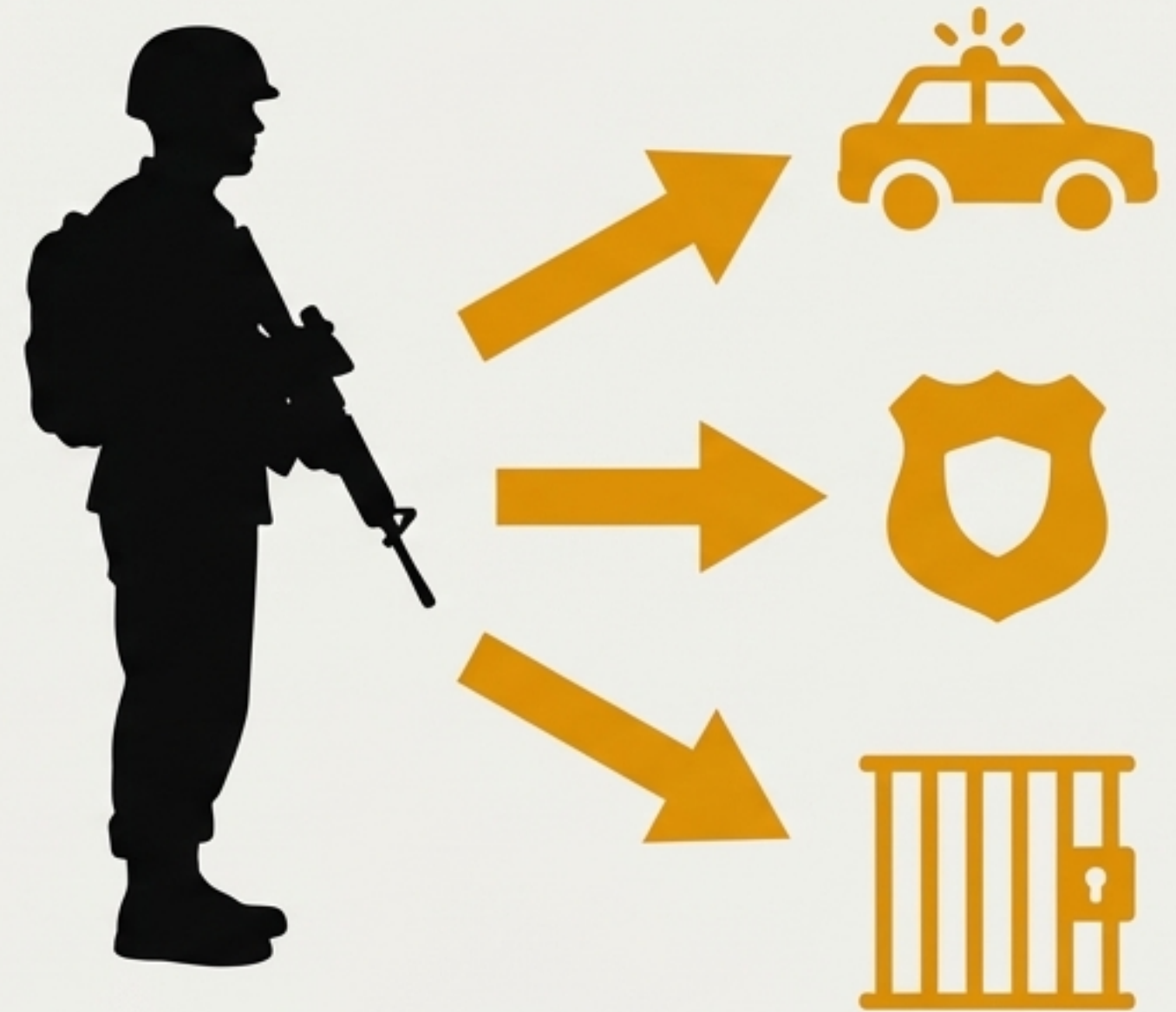
Traditional transition tools like *My Next Move for Veterans* often recommend a narrow set of roles based on surface-level similarities, primarily in security and law enforcement.

Conventional Matches

Police and Sheriff's Patrol Officers
Correctional Officers and Jailers
Security Guards
Private Detectives and Investigators

The Mismatch

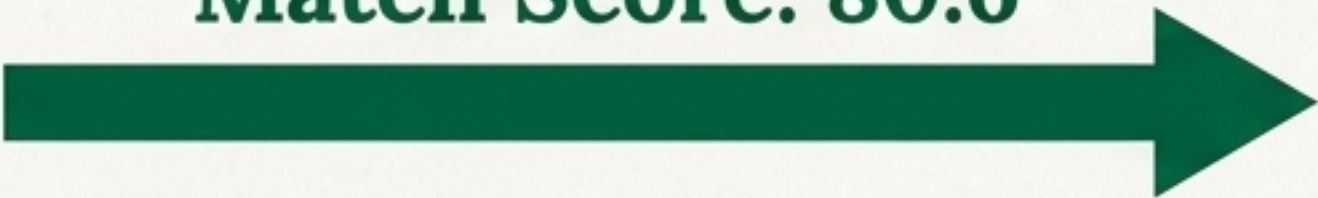
While these roles use some skills, they often overlook critical abilities in teamwork, complex problem-solving under extreme pressure, and equipment maintenance.



Our data reveals an unexpected, high-quality match: Firefighter, based on deep similarities in core abilities and work styles.

Infantry Rifleman
(MOS 0311)

Match Score: 80.6



Firefighter

Infantry Rifleman Attributes	Shared Attribute Type	Firefighter Attributes
Public Safety & Security Education & Training	Shared Knowledge	Public Safety & Security Education & Training
Coordination, Judgment & Decision Making, Critical Thinking, Complex Problem Solving	Shared Skills	Coordination, Judgment & Decision Making, Critical Thinking, Complex Problem Solving
Stamina, Static Strength, Trunk Strength	Shared Abilities	Stamina, Static Strength, Trunk Strength
Dependability, Attention to Detail, Cooperation, Leadership, Stress Tolerance, Integrity	Shared Work Styles	Dependability, Attention to Detail, Cooperation, Leadership, Stress Tolerance, Integrity

The match is driven not by the task of “fighting,” but by shared requirements for physical resilience, teamwork, equipment maintenance, and critical thinking in high-stakes environments.

The methodology uncovers powerful, non-obvious career paths across all services.

Case Study: Navy Aviation Structural Mechanic (AM)

An AM's expertise in maintaining airframes, hydraulics, and structural components translates far beyond typical aviation roles.

Top 5 High-Quality, Non-Supervisory Matches for an AM			
Civilian Occupation	Median Wages	Education at Entry	Match Score
Firefighters	\$52,500	Postsecondary nondegree award	96.0
Millwrights	\$57,300	High school diploma	95.6
Commercial Divers	\$54,800	Postsecondary nondegree award	89.3
Electricians	\$56,900	High school diploma	88.3
Aircraft Mechanics	\$66,400	Postsecondary nondegree award	87.1

Why it Works: The AM-to-Millwright match is driven by shared KSAs in Mechanical Knowledge, Troubleshooting, Repairing, Equipment Maintenance, and Attention to Detail.

It precisely translates highly technical military skills into high-demand civilian equivalents.

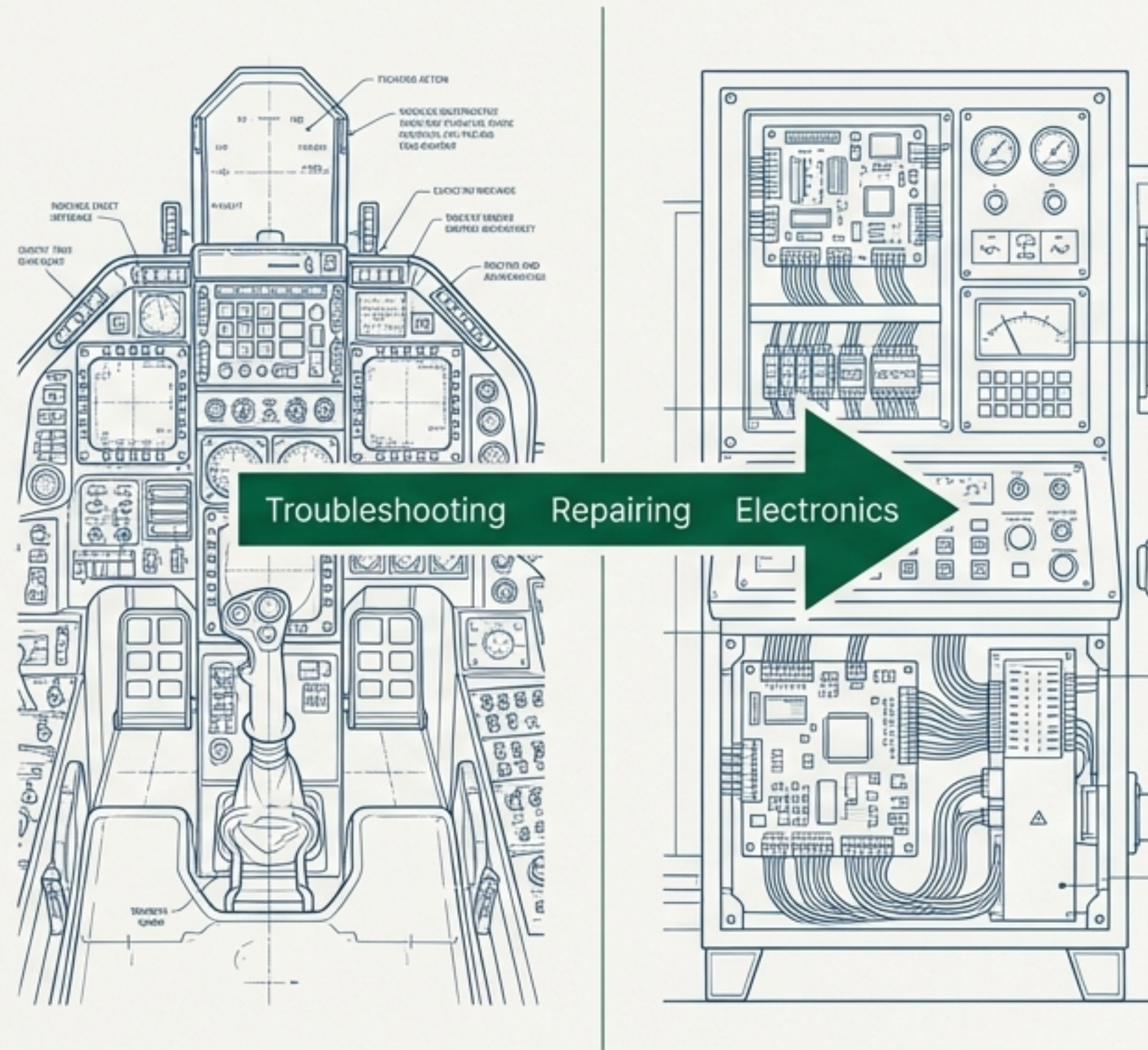
Case Study: Air Force Fighter Aircraft Integrated Avionics Specialist (AFSC 2A3X4)

This role involves troubleshooting, installing, and repairing complex aircraft avionic systems, a skill set highly valued in the civilian sector.

Top High-Quality Match: Electrical and Electronic Repairers, Commercial & Industrial Equipment (Match Score: 82.9)

Why it Works: This is a powerful match based on deep overlap in technical domains.

- Top 2 Shared Knowledge Areas: Mechanical, Computers & Electronics.
- Top 2 Shared Skills: Troubleshooting, Repairing.
- Top Shared Work Styles: Attention to Detail, Integrity, Initiative.



Key Findings: A Data-Driven Path to Better Veteran Employment Outcomes



Unlocking Hidden Potential

Every military occupation studied yielded at least two high-quality civilian matches, and often many more. The methodology consistently uncovers sensible, high-value career paths missed by traditional translation tools.



Identifying Generalizable Military Skills

The data reveals a core set of skills common across most military roles—leadership, teamwork, stress tolerance, and dependability—that are highly valued in supervisory and high-stakes civilian jobs like Firefighting.



Pinpointing the Greatest Need

The analysis also identifies roles with very few high-quality matches (e.g., Marine Rifleman, Navy Boatswain's Mate). This allows for the strategic targeting of transition assistance resources to the veterans who need them most.

Recommendations: Integrating Skill-Based Matching to Fundamentally Improve the Transition Process



1. Enhance Existing Transition Tools

Integrate these research findings and the expanded set of occupational matches into the My Next Move for Veterans website and the Transition Assistance Program (TAP) curriculum to give service members a wider, more accurate aperture of possibilities.



2. Target Support for Hard-to-Match Occupations

Investigate providing additional, specialized transition services and career counseling for service members in occupations identified with few high-quality civilian matches.



3. Educate Civilian Employers

Use the detailed KSA comparisons to help employers better understand how specific military occupations align with their requirements for open positions, breaking down misconceptions based on job titles.

By focusing on the fundamental building blocks of work, we can create more efficient and effective pathways for the 200,000 service members who enter the civilian workforce each year.